



BEFORE

By the mid-19th century, intelligence was recognized as a crucial element in warfare. But when the Civil War erupted, neither side had intelligence organizations.

NAPOLEON'S INFORMATION GATHERING

Civil War generals had studied the **Napoleonic Wars** of 1803–15 and were aware of the importance the French emperor, Napoleon, had accorded to intelligence. Information gathered from varied sources—foreign newspapers, interrogation of prisoners, and secret agents—was sifted and collated by Napoleon's general staff to build **a picture of the enemy's strength, movements, and intentions**. The efforts of the enemy to gather information were countered by the use of **ciphers for written messages** and secret police to track down enemy spies.

U.S. INTELLIGENCE

America had no such system. The Signal Corps, a U.S. Army innovation of 1860, was in its infancy. In the early days of the war, **intelligence and counterintelligence were improvised**. Private detective Allan Pinkerton was a key figure on the Union side, his agents acting as a proto-secret service. Virginia governor John Letcher set up a spy network in Washington, while **Virginians still had free access to the capital**.

Sources of intelligence in the Civil War were varied, some traditional and some innovative. For example, alongside cavalry reconnaissance came observation from balloons. Pioneered by the French in the 1790s, the idea for balloons was revived in 1861 through the initiative of an individual enthusiast, Thaddeus Lowe, who offered his services to the Union. Interception of written communications was age-old, but during the war telegraph-tapping also became common, increasing the need for ciphers to make messages secure.

Uncensored newspapers procured from the enemy lines were a prime source of information. Journalists often naively revealed details of movements and plans, although false articles were sometimes planted to confuse the enemy. Mapmaking was an important intelligence activity when fighting over uncharted terrain. The Confederates, fighting mostly on their own soil, could expect local people to update them on Union movements. For Northerners, slaves and former slaves—known collectively as “black dispatches”—were a valuable source of information. Documents found on dead or wounded enemies, or simply left in a field—as happened during Lee’s Maryland campaign—all potentially aided the opponent’s cause.